

v8 recovers the cool factor v7 stripped. Bringing back from v1: - Kyle's calculations on the page (firing solutions, time dilation, 0.3-second windows, the array as a coal being blown to life). - "Welded industrial grief" architecture iconography. - Kyle as physical figure of menace — threshold moment, weapon anatomy, six-feet-of-nothing physical read. - Short declarative thesis-lines (Surprise was free. Kneecaps are math.). - Rare italic inner-voice flags (one or two, not constant).

Held from v7: - Short paragraphs, white space as pacing. - No parenthetical narrator asides. - No sword mythology (no corundum strop, no piezoelectric). - Corp objects do double duty (indictment + metaphor). - Environment as metaphor for inhabitants. - One unbranded object at the moral fulcrum (the teeth). - Trail-leads-upstream as the closer.

Bearing Teeth

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

I

The freight elevator had a Carrion Logistics LLC inspection sticker dated last week and a control panel that had not worked since 2218.

It went up at the speed it had decided on. The cage was steel grating. Concrete dust on the floor said somebody had moved a refrigerator. The ceiling LED was the wrong color and bathed everything in the institutional green of a hospital cafeteria at three in the morning.

The resident elevator did not exist anymore. There was a shaft and there were doors. One of the doors had a paper sign that said OUT OF SERVICE in three languages, none of them issued by anyone who had ever fixed an elevator.

The airshaft brought the building up the side of the cage. Camphor from the second. Burnt rice from the fifth, the same Thursday burnt rice since 2189. Pork bone and scallion and old oil from somewhere between four and seven.

Mrs. Chen's stall. The smell of the contract waiting for him at the top.

Kyle stepped off on the eighth.

Unit 802. A door painted white four times by four people who had each disagreed about what white was.

She opened on the second knock.

"Come in, Mr. Corbin."

She had been trying his name for the duration of the phone call. *Corbin* was as close as she had gotten and he was not going to correct her.

The front room had a folding chair, a low table, and a television last turned on the year before last. On top of it: clementines, envelopes, and a small

carved wooden frog with a chip out of its left back leg.

The husband sat in the corner.

A wicker chair. Two breaks in the cane, both wrapped in electrical tape. He held his weight off the broken places the way a man held his weight off a thing he had stopped expecting the use of. His jaw was wired. Four-point titanium. A Carrion field-clinic job. The kind of job a Carrion field clinic did when the patient was billed against the same Carrion property registry the field clinic operated out of, and the field clinic had the budget the Carrion property registry had decided to give it, which was not enough for plates.

"My husband's name is Liu," she said. "He was a cook. He was a very good cook."

Liu blinked at Kyle.

Kyle bowed. Liu's blink returned it.

The light fixture was a Pinnacle Civil house-brand bulb from a 2210 closeout sale. The Pinnacle Civil CEO had been indicted in 2217 for routing the firm's taxes through a shell he also ran. Forty-six bulbs left in the world. Chen Wei-Lin had bought twelve. She was on her seventh.

Across the canyon, the tower opposite had a Hyacinth Property Management sticker on the western face, peeling. Hyacinth had pulled out of residential management in 2218. The sticker had been there since.

In a window two buildings over, a man was arguing with a ride-share AI. His shoulders said he had been losing for six minutes. Kyle wished him well.

"The men who came," Mrs. Chen said.

"Yes."

"There were six. The one I want is Tien."

She did not point at her husband. The husband was already pointed at.

"He hit my husband three times with the back of a wrench. The first on the side of the head. The second on the jaw. The third on the jaw also. After the third he was satisfied."

"Why."

"The license."

The Carrion stall license. Three thousand Φ a year. Twelve installments unless one was missed. Then one installment plus interest plus a man named Tien, the visit itemized on the invoice as *Compliance Verification*. Carrion reported it to investors as enforcement-margin revenue. The 2225 annual report had cited it as evidence of operational health.

The Chens' jaw was operational health.

"You were short this month."

"Eight hundred."

"Why."

"The cold snap. We ran the fryer harder. The gas bill cleared on the third. Tien came on the second."

Arcturus had run its February atmospheric maintenance window in March. They had announced it in a press release nobody read. The Chens had paid for it in fryer gas. The corp that owned the processors and the corp that issued the license were the same corp through three intermediaries that did not, on any public filing, agree to be the same corp.

They were the same corp.

A curtain shifted in the back room.

A face appeared at the gap. Twelve. Maybe thirteen. Her father's jaw, before the wrench. Her mother's eyes.

Kyle did not look at her directly.

Mrs. Chen had not turned. She knew.

She pressed credits into his palm. A pink hair-elastic banded them. The chips were warm. Six hundred and forty Φ . Half the standing rate.

"I do not have all of it, Mr. Corbin."

"It is enough."

"I do not have all—"

"Mrs. Chen. It is enough."

Her hands stopped trembling, second knuckle of the index first, the rest in a half-second cascade.

Upstairs, somebody played a Cantonese pop song from 2218. A streaming service had served it to the building at funerals for the four years it was a hit. The song was not for Liu Chen. Liu Chen was still alive.

It was on retainer.

"You will be careful, Mr. Corbin."

"I will be efficient."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

She bowed. He bowed. He left.

II

The bike was matte black under a tier-six awning that did half the work of keeping it dry.

Three plates magnetized to the underside of the rear cowl. He chose the one issued to a Carrion subcontractor in 2206 that had never been cancelled. The Gray Zone surveillance grid was Pinnacle Civic Vision hardware, forty years old, cast off when Pinnacle had moved its product line to the corporation district. A Carrion plate went where a Carrion plate had ever been. Carrion plates had been most places.

He rode south.

The freight ramps had not been maintained since Arcturus had withdrawn from the residential market in 2218 to focus on higher-margin verticals. Each ramp dropped him eight stories. By the third the architecture had stopped pretending to be architecture and had become what it actually was, which was welded industrial grief. By the fifth the rain was warmer — upper-tier rain came from cloud, lower-tier rain had been through six tiers of Arcturus exhaust on the way down.

The sky where he could see it was the bruise the GLMZ sky was at this hour — orange under, indigo over, the Pulse-corridor light pollution running east-west across the middle like a healing scar.

A VTOL crossed the gap forty stories above. Amber lights. Some board director was late to dinner. Forty stories below the board director, in a stairwell that smelled like ammonia, a child whose grandmother had died because Hyacinth had reclassified stairwells as common-area-not-habitable was learning to read the dark.

The grandmother had been ninety-one.

The lighting code had been amended in committee.

The bike was running clean.

He parked a block out. He walked.

III

The loading dock sat where the eastern strut met tier-zero substrate and tier-zero substrate was just concrete.

The building was on the Arcturus property registry as *industrial — out of service — pending evaluation*. Arcturus had been pending evaluation on this building since 2218.

A Carrion Logistics LLC gantry above the slip had MOVING WHAT MATTERS stenciled across it in a font that had outlasted three of the men standing under it.

Six bays. Two roller doors open. Amber sodium overheads from before LED was a word. Everything looked like a polaroid in a kitchen drawer.

A man at the corner of the alley was trying to sell stolen ramen to a stevedore who didn't want stolen ramen. They were still working it out.

Kyle stood at the threshold.

He is six feet of nothing. That is the first thing. A swimmer's build stripped past lean into something the body shouldn't sustain. The hardware in his skull bills him in calories. He has been paying the invoice in flesh since he was sixteen.

The katana rides his right shoulder in a matte friction sheath. A hundred and two centimeters. The ito on the hilt is dark with use.

On his low left hip rides Chorus. Bird's-head grip. No stock. The silhouette of an oversized revolver under a coat. Five chambers. Four buckshot, one slug, the slug seated on top because he had loaded it that way on the off chance he encountered the kind of door tonight a slug would solve.

He crossed the threshold and stood still and let them look.

Six men. Card game on a crate. Pai gow with hand-marked tiles because somebody had spilled something on the cards a week ago and nobody had replaced them. Tien was winning. Tien was always winning. The others had figured this out and had agreed, quietly, to let him.

Two chrome-arm men leaned on a stack of dollies. Hydraulic Solutions ARM-9s, recalled in 2222 for an elbow flexor that locked at full extension under stress. Hydraulic Solutions had recalled them. Hydraulic Solutions also required certified ID at the service window. The two men did not have certified ID because their IDs were sitting in a Lotus Syndicate drawer as collateral on the financing for the arms. The corp that sold the arms and the corp that took the men's IDs ran on the same authentication protocol.

This was not a coincidence.

One man at the table had subdermal thoracic plating ridged at the collar — low-end clinic, fast install, the kind of work the Helix subcontractors did after Helix had stopped inspecting them in 2222.

One had chrome knuckles. Nineteen. Cosmetic. Very fresh. Hydraulic Solutions consumer credit. If he survived the year, the arm would cost him three times the install price.

One had no visible work. Internal. Expensive. Decisions.

The last had a face rebuilt cheap and tight on the left side. The skin pulled the wrong way over the lower mandible. The parts of his face had run out somewhere along the line.

Tien.

The laughter died at the tempo laughter died when the math changed in a room. It died last in the chrome-knuckle kid. Nineteen. Hadn't learned the tempo.

The no-visible-work man set his tiles face down.

"You lost, friend?"

"Looking for Tien."

The man looked at Tien. Tien looked at the man. The man looked back at Kyle. He had decided to make this take one more sentence than it needed to.

"Tien is occupied."

"He won't be."

Kyle's chest warmed.

Not the bracer he was not wearing. Not the blade. The array.

A coal blown to life behind the sternum. Thirty-two thousand electrodes coming up from rest cycle to operating cycle, the firmware allocating from the bio-battery the resolution that the situation required. The room rendered itself in the second channel.

Six bodies. Heat signatures. Pulse rates.

Firing solutions, one through six, ranked by the lethality threshold each subject presented.

The kid's right forearm flexor tightening at the wrist as the hand moved toward the waistband — telegraphed at the shoulder a full half-second before the hand committed.

The subdermal-plated man's center of gravity sitting one inch forward of where it had been sitting forty seconds ago.

The near chrome-arm man's hydraulic shoulder waking up the actuator bus, the electromagnetic bloom signature reading clean across the planter.

The far chrome-arm man's right hand already drifting back toward the elbow joint where the ARM-9's manual release was — a man who had been told what to do if the recall fired, who had not been told it would fire tonight.

The saya inside the boss's coat, visible to the array as a hard linear shadow inside the soft draping of the fabric.

Tien sat very still and watched, which was Tien's correct response. Tien had made it to thirty-four in this work by knowing exactly which fights were his and exactly which fights were not. This was not one of his.

Six bodies. Six firing solutions. A half-second window before any of them would commit to the motion the array had already painted.

They laughed first. You remember that. They laughed first.

"Kyle from down the street."

The boss smiled.

Chorus came out of the holster in Kyle's left hand.

Crack — crack-crack-crack.

The cylinder rotated under his trigger finger between shots with the slow deliberate click of a revolver that had been polished by every cleaning since he had owned it. The sound was not a series of cracks. It was concussion, four times in three seconds, twelve-gauge in concrete with no acoustic mercy, the pressure stacking against the eardrums and the sternum and the fillings in the back teeth. The bay's amber overheads strobed twice from the muzzle flash and resumed.

Buckshot at the kid's right knee. The joint did not bend. It separated, the way a poorly-glued cabinet door came apart when somebody finally pulled it the right way. He went down sideways. The sound he made was not screaming. Screaming required composure.

Slug at the subdermal man's left knee. His fighting philosophy had ended at his chest. The kneecap had not been consulted. He folded with the dignified slow collapse of a man whose center of gravity had done him the courtesy of waiting until he had reached the floor to abandon him.

Slug at the near chrome-arm's right knee. Hydraulics did not load-bear on the leg. The leg was flesh. He sat down hard against the dollies. The dollies rolled six inches.

Slug at Tien's left knee. At the angle the array had specified. Tien's face met the corrugated steel of the drainage channel. Two teeth came loose on impact. The third would not.

Three seconds. Four shots. Four men down. One slug left in the cylinder.

Surprise was free. Surprise was always free.

The far chrome-arm had started his swing in the half-second between the first shot and the second.

Correct response. A fighter with hydraulic reach and a head start on the geometry. The arm was already coming around at the height where Kyle's collarbone had been. The array read the motor bus — clean electromagnetic bloom along the deltoid actuator, full lateral extension committed, intercept at the throat — and Kyle, who had not put the katana away because the katana had never been the point of putting away, stepped under the arc.

The blade cleared the saya in one continuous draw. Right hand over the right shoulder. One motion.

He put the edge into the shoulder seam where chrome met flesh.

Three and a half centimeters of unprotected actuator housing exposed at the cooling vent. A gap Helix had designed into the ARM-9 in 2221 because the cooling-vent redesign that would have closed it had been over budget. The corporation accountants had filed the over-budget under *unfunded improvement opportunity*, a term that meant the corp had priced the fix and elected not to perform it.

Helix had decided, in 2221, that his shoulder was the cheaper option.

The edge passed through the gap the way an edge passed through anything when the angle was right.

Tink.

The arm did not stop. The arm finished its swing into empty air without its owner. The motor bus was severed at the shoulder. The rest of his body did what bodies did when the load-bearing chrome stopped sending signals.

Then the elbow flexor locked at full extension.

Hydraulic Solutions had recalled it in 2222. The man had never brought it in. The dead arm went stiff at his side like a man hailing a cab.

The street, by tomorrow afternoon, would have a new entry in its file on the blade: *cuts chrome*. The street would attribute the cut to whatever ability the street currently believed the blade had. None of the street's hypotheses would be the explanation. The edge had cut the chrome because the edge was sharp and the chrome had a seam and Kyle had put the edge in the seam.

He had stopped offering the explanation. The people he had explained it to had a way of dying mid-explanation.

The blade was a sword. The audience was responsible for its own categories.

Kyle turned.

The boss had stood up.

He had not drawn during the count. He stood the way a man stood when he had watched his crew dismantle on schedule and had decided it was now his turn.

The hand went to his hip. The blade came out at the right angle in the right tempo. The guard settled into a stance from no school Kyle could name.

The man knew his work.

Somebody had paid for the work. Korean swordsman, sourced in Seoul, imported on a Helix procurement officer's budget line filed against an Atlas-program continuation directorate that did not, on any public filing, exist. The trail upstream of him ran through three committees and out the top of a building in Geneva where the people who had signed the budget line did not, individually, know they had signed for a swordsman. Their budget lines did not specify swords.

Their budget lines specified outcomes.

The outcome was on the dock floor tonight.

"Sloppy entrance."

He said it like a teacher correcting homework. The Korean inflected through the English of someone who had paid for the English along with the swordwork.

Kyle did not answer.

The array dropped into the second channel and started timing.

They closed.

First exchange. The man tested the line. A short cut at Kyle's right shoulder. No commitment in it. The kind of strike a swordsman used to read his opponent's reach and tempo.

Kyle's blade rose. The steel met edge to flat at a shallow angle.

Tang.

The note rang clean and sustained in the concrete. The man read his information off Kyle's reach and tempo and stepped back without expression. His weight stayed off the front foot.

He is not going to give you anything until he has decided you are worth giving it to.

Second exchange. Kyle pressed. Two-step advance, cut high right. The man deflected rather than parried — slid Kyle's flat past his shoulder. Smart. Conservative. He had been trained against blades that did things the corporations had been telling buyers about for thirty years, and none of what he had been told to expect was going to arrive.

Third exchange. The man committed. Cut high left, fast, clean, no telegraph. Kyle's parry was a fraction late because the man had given him nothing to read. The follow-through grazed Kyle's left forearm. Three inches of skin opened.

Vein not artery. Two centimeters lateral of the radial. Will not bleed out. Will impair grip on the shotgun side in approximately ninety seconds.

Blood came up immediately.

The man saw the blood. He read it as the answer to the question he had been asking, which was *am I better than the man this is supposed to be*. He had decided he was. The corp that had paid for his curriculum would have endorsed the decision.

The corp was wrong.

Fourth exchange. The thrust. Straight. Committed. Full extension. The line clean.

Kyle did not meet it at the edge.

He met it at the seppa. The small collar between the tsuba and the blade. The thrust locked there, blade to blade, no give.

Kyle drove forward. He kept the lock. He let the edge ride along the flat of the man's steel like a skate on ice, the edge tracking from tip toward middle toward tsuba, and where the man's blade met the man's hand, the edge met the man's right wrist.

Bone. Tendon. The radial and ulnar arteries. The median nerve. The carpal architecture that had held a sword for whatever number of years the man had been training for this duel.

The wrist and the sword fell together to the corrugated steel.

Clang.

The man looked at his wrist. He looked at his sword on the floor. He looked at Kyle.

"Oh."

The brachial did most of the work. Nineteen seconds. The array timed it. The array timed everything.

Twenty-three seconds for the duel. Twenty-six on the dock floor end to end.

Kyle's hands were steady. They would shake in four minutes. He had learned to use the window.

Kneecaps are math. Duel is discipline. The blade is just a sword.

He sheathed the blade. A thin line of red near the kissaki. He wiped it on the man's coat. Chorus went back into the holster. Four chambers spent. One slug left.

IV

Tien was crying. Not screaming. Crying.

He had figured out by the third kneecap that he was not going to die tonight. The prospect of *not dying tonight* in his current condition was striking him as worse than the alternative.

Kyle crouched.

He found the two loose teeth on the steel where Tien's face had landed. Two intact.

The third was still seated. He took it with a thumb and forefinger and a small clean turn. It came free.

Three teeth in his left hand.

Behind the ventilation unit on the far wall, the breathing shifted.

Twelve. Maybe thirteen. She had been there since the threshold.

She had come down. He did not know how. He did not need to.

He walked to the unit. He did not go behind it. He stood where she could see him — a tall, blood-misted shape in the dock's bad amber — and he waited.

The breathing stopped.

A face came around the corner. Her father's jaw, before the wrench. Her mother's eyes. The expression was a child's expression that had not been issued to a child before tonight.

Kyle crouched. He went down to her eye level the way Seo had once told him a child should always be met. *Be at their height when you speak to them.*

The teeth lay in his palm. Two intact. The third with a hairline fracture from where he had gripped it.

There was no Carrion sticker on them. No corp manifest. No serial. No QR. No subscription number. No registry classification. No batch identifier. No barcode. No anti-counterfeit thread. No optical hologram. No royalty markup.

Just three teeth, warm.

"Present these to your father. I think he will appreciate the gesture."

She looked at the teeth. Then at him. Then at the teeth.

She held out her hands. Cupped.

He poured them in.

She did not drop them.

She shrieked, high and thin, off every hard surface in the dock and back. She did not drop them. Her fingers closed.

She looked at her closed hands.

She looked at him.

She bowed. Full. From the waist. Two seconds. Hands cupped at her chest the whole time.

Then she was gone, swallowed by the dark beyond the door. Her feet made no sound on the steel because she had been raised in a building where you learned, by five, not to make sound on steel.

Kyle stood for three seconds.

He cleaned the blade. The tremor started in his right hand at the four-minute mark and went briefly bilateral — the array's invoice arriving, several

thousand calories called in twenty-six seconds, the body presenting the bill. His stomach was a closed fist.

He walked back to the bike.

The bike started on the first turn. He swapped the plate two blocks short of the Wicker boundary and continued north on a different fiction.

V

Chen's stall was two blocks south of the freight tier. The hood lamp was visible through the rain from a block away.

He walked the bike the last block.

She was at the counter. Service apron. The kitchen apron was at home.

She did not greet him. She set a bowl down.

Pork bone broth. Fourteen-hour. The stockpot at the back of the stall was a 1987 Foshan thirty-quart that had outlasted her two husbands and three cities. The pot was the only thing in the building that worked. No Carrion sticker. No Hyacinth registry. No Arcturus subscription. No Helix calibration certificate. The pot did its work without filing.

Chili oil was already in the bowl. The way she would remember he liked it for the next four years.

Three quick ladle dips. First skim. Second stir. Third draw. The third was the one she poured.

He sat.

He did not sit anywhere else. At Mrs. Chen's he sat. Not because she offered. Because she had offered.

He ate the bowl. He did not speak.

She did not refill it. She did not move.

When he set the chopsticks down she was still standing where she had been.

She had more to give. She was finding the language for it.

Mh̄gōi. Low. Cantonese.

Then: "Free. Always. For you. Forever."

Her hands were flat on the counter. Her scarred thumb was the closest thing to him on the wood.

He reached into his coat and set a credit chip on the counter beside her hand. Standard rate.

"I pay. Every bowl. Standard rate. Every time."

She did not pick up the chip. He did not pick up the bowl. Four seconds.

"You took the contract at half. You did the work whole. The bowl is nothing. Forever is nothing."

He did not move the chip.

"If I do not pay, I do not eat. If I do not eat here, I do not eat. I would rather pay you than not see you again. The chip stays."

Five seconds.

Her hand closed over the chip the way her daughter's hand had closed over the teeth.

She bowed. The bow she would give him every night for the next four years. The bow of a vendor accepting a price.

He bowed back, smaller. The bow of a man who had successfully refused a kindness larger than he could carry.

"Tomorrow. Same bowl. Same price."

"Same price."

The agreement was the contract. The contract was the bond.

He turned and walked the bike out of the lamp circle.

The rain had not stopped.

The towers leaned in the way they did this far down. Above the gap an Arcturus advertising drone was projecting THE FUTURE THAT WORKS FOR YOU on the side of a residential tower whose lower three floors had been condemned eighteen months ago and had not been demolished because the demolition was on a Hyacinth schedule and the Hyacinth schedule was full. The lower three floors had people in them. The people had not been on any registry since 2222.

He laughed.

A single tight exhalation. The kind of laugh you laughed when the alternative was the alternative.

He had walked into a room of six men who would have killed an ordinary person for trying it, and he had walked out, and he had refused free noodles from a woman whose entire life he had just rearranged, and he was doing it because honor was a discipline and the discipline did not bend for noodles, and any reasonable observer would have concluded he had lost his mind.

He had not.

He was the exception to the rule.

The rule said a man performing samurai discipline in 2226 would be killed for it inside a year. The rule was correct about almost everybody. It was not correct about him. The city had built counters for many things. The corporations had paid for most of them.

They had not yet decided he was the kind of problem worth paying for.

He was going to die at some point.

In the meantime, the noodles had been the right temperature, the chip had stayed on the counter, and the rain was warm at this tier.

He laughed once more, smaller. He rode home.

VI

Somebody had been watching the dock.

A camera. Second floor of the building across the alley. A panel of plywood replaced with a panel that looked like the rest but was not. The feed ran on a private channel that did not touch the Carrion grid.

The watcher was a woman named Hira Volkova. Forty-two. Tea, not coffee. A bowl of dried apricots she did not like but ate because they were quiet.

Her salary cleared through four shell companies routed through a Helix subsidiary whose only employee was a man in Singapore who had not been to the office in six years.

She watched the walk back to the bike. She noted the pace. She noted that Kyle's hand did not move toward the saya at any point. She noted the breathing telemetry her organization had access to on infrastructure that did not officially exist stayed at the rest cycle.

She noted the cut to the chrome-arm's shoulder seam. No flare. No arc. The blade had found a gap.

She wrote this down. Correct reports lowered the risk premium. Lower risk premiums got passed up the chain to people who appreciated lower risk premiums.

She noted one thing she did not write down.

On a microphone better than anyone on the dock had known was there, Kyle had muttered a phrase between the wrist falling and the blade going back in the saya. Three syllables. Not in any language Kyle spoke. She ran it against eleven candidate corpora. Eighty-one-percent match to a sub-variant of Tocharian B that had not been adequately preserved in any extant corpus.

Approximate translation: *we have him now.*

She did not put it in the report.

She filed it on the encrypted side of her personal log, on a directory she had not touched in three years.

The things you filed separately were the things that turned out to be the answer.

The report would be reviewed two months later by Hua, south-arm cell captain of the Lotus Syndicate. Hua would close the file and pass it to her gang lieutenant Mira with a second file labelled *Bucktown — first interview — fourteen-piece*.

The Tocharian was not in the report Hua read.

Kyle rode home.

The noodles would be cold by morning. They always were.

The hum in his chest was at 19Hz. The frequency a NeoCortex Atlas research grade had been broadcasting since the boy from the Grind was sixteen. The boy from the Grind did not yet know who else was tuned to that frequency.

The people who had tuned them both did not have to know either.

That was the trick.

The trick was that nobody who built the city had to know the city anymore.

The trail led upstream. The upstream had been engineered, by people whose names were on contracts the public could not read, to lead nowhere a working person could reach.

That was the work of years.

Tonight was the work of one night.

Tonight, the work was done.

Hira put another apricot in her mouth. She chewed it without enthusiasm. She watched the bike's running light fade north into the rain.

The city continued.

The corporations continued.

The trail continued upstream.

The teeth in the daughter's cupped hands continued home.

That was the only thing on the cross-street tonight that did not have a sticker on it.

She was twelve.

She would remember.